

Forrest Gump — The Movie Review

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Today is 30 years from THAT July 6th in 1994 that Forrest Gump debuted in theaters nationwide. Directed by Robert Zemeckis and starring Tom Hanks, the movie was based on the 1986 novel Forrest Gump by Winston Groom. To this day Forrest is an iconic fictional figure in our popular culture. He is one of the most beloved characters.

I can remember my sister Reneé taking me to see it. I was just a boy, but there was something I liked about Forrest. I got the book, a paperback edition that I still have. Little did I know, that years later I would myself interviewing Winston Groom in his house on a very hot day in April. After our talk, he autographed that book with a personal message.

The next year, I interviewed Michael Conner Humphreys, who played young Forrest in the movie. That interview has become the most popular interview I ever did. Maybe the book and the movie have had a bigger impact on my life than I thought. Having watched the movie version I don't know how many times, I decided to watch it last night and try to put myself in the frame of mind that I was seeing it for the very first time. Not so easy to do.

Forrest Gump is an emotional tale

I'd start off by saying that Forrest Gump is first and foremost an emotional tale, but along the way it has adventure, action, love, heartbreak and loss. It intertwines with many moments in American history. In the center of it all, the main character never changes his core values. Although Forrest's IQ is lower than most, he is nonetheless steadfast.

Tom Hanks portrayal of Forrest Gump may be his most known role. And it occurred to me that it was his ability to portray a person who is both wise and "not a smart man," as the character describes himself. Therein is a valuable life lesson. If your mind can't wrap around what the most intelligent act would be, go with the kind of wisdom your mama gave you.

The movie is told almost entirely through the reminiscing of Forrest sitting on a bench at a bus stop. Forrest's strength as a storyteller comes down to his innocence and ability to break down a story to the essentials. Meeting a President is on equal footing

as getting free Dr Peppers.

The story is remarkable and full

Screenwriter Eric Roth told an, at times, different tale from the book, but managed to inject so many events in a bit over two hours and twenty minutes. We witness Forrest interact with many notable events.

He gets a football scholarship from the University of Alabama where he's coached by Bear Bryant. He witnesses Alabama Governor George Wallace try to block desegregation at the school. Forrest serves in an infantry division in Vietnam, meets Presidents Kennedy, Johnson and Nixon. He gets thrust on stage at the anti-war march at the National Mall in Washington DC, starts a shrimping business and runs multiple times across the United States. There's even more.

You meet a variety of characters throughout the movie, and some of them vary in their treatment of Forrest, but he realizes that events and objects come and go. Forrest's loyalty to his friends never wanes. It's especially true of Jenny, the girl he falls in love with in grade school. And it's true of Lt. Dan and Bubba, his closest friends he meets in combat in Vietnam. He sticks with them even when they don't deserve his devotion. Loyalty is his defining characteristic.

Forrest Gump has an incredible soundtrack and score

Watching the movie again, I also realize how meticulous the score and the soundtrack are. They really accentuate the movie. They picked some of the greatest artists ever to tell the story, from Duane Eddy, Creedence Clearwater Revival, Bob Dylan, the Youngbloods, Jackson Browne, Fleetwood Mac, Willie Nelson and Bob Seger. The music is all incredible, and surely must have cost a bundle.

Forrest and his story endure

Having met Winston Groom, the man who birthed the character of Forrest, it's hard not to think of him after seeing the movie. I can't help but think that Forrest and Winston had a lot in common. Both of them were natural storytellers. Neither had any pretension. Both could say without a doubt, "at least I didn't lead no humdrum life," to quote Forrest in the book.

That's the story of Forrest Gump and the magic of the film. He had his limitations, but he did all of these things anyway. Forrest and his story endure.